



Q

What is the ideal starting temperature for drying most fruits and vegetables in a dehydrator to prevent spoilage?

DEHYDRATING AND SMOKING



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

140° to 150°F

FUN FACT

Starting drying too low can cause food to spoil before it dries!

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables



Q

Why is removing moisture from food crucial in drying preservation?



ANSWER

It prevents microorganisms from growing, which causes spoilage.

FUN FACT

Drying is one of the oldest food preservation methods, used for thousands of years!

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely



Q

What temperature should jerky be heated to after drying to ensure it is safe to eat?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

275°F for 10 minutes

FUN FACT

Heating jerky after drying kills harmful microbes that drying alone might not destroy.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely



Q

Before smoking fish, what must form on the surface to help the smoke stick evenly?



ANSWER

A pellicle, a shiny, slightly tacky skin

FUN FACT

The pellicle also helps prevent spoilage during smoking!

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home



Q

What is the recommended salt to water ratio in a brine solution for salting fish before smoking?



ANSWER

1 part table salt to 7 parts water

FUN FACT

Using a salometer helps measure the exact salt concentration!

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home



Q

What is a key safety concern when making jerky from ground meat?



ANSWER

Grinding spreads bacteria throughout the meat, increasing risk.

FUN FACT

Ground meat jerky requires extra care because pathogens can be mixed inside.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely



Q

When drying pumpkin or squash pieces, to what dryness should you dry before storage?



ANSWER

Tough and brittle with no moisture

FUN FACT

If moisture remains, return pieces to the dehydrator to finish drying!

Source: SP 50-921 Drying herbs



Q

How long should fruit leather be dried at 140°F in a dehydrator for it to be done?



ANSWER

About 10 hours until no sticky areas remain

FUN FACT

Test fruit leather dryness by gently touching-no indentation means done!

Source: SP 50-921 Drying herbs



Q

Why is it important to dry foods in a single layer on dehydrator trays?



ANSWER

So the air can circulate evenly and dry all pieces properly.

FUN FACT

Drying similar sized pieces together helps all dry at the same rate.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables



Q

What is the main reason shelf-stable jerky can be stored without refrigeration?



ANSWER

Most moisture has been removed to prevent microbial growth.

FUN FACT

16 ounces raw meat usually makes about 4 ounces of jerky.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely



Q

Why should onions and peppers be dried separately from mild foods?



ANSWER

Their strong flavors can transfer and affect other foods.

FUN FACT

Avoid mixing strong-smelling foods with mild ones for best flavor.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables



Q

What happens if you start drying food at too low a temperature?



ANSWER

The food may spoil before it dries.

FUN FACT

Starting at 140° to 150°F helps prevent spoilage early on!

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables



Q

What is 'conditioning' in the context of dried foods?



ANSWER

Storing dried food in an airtight container for a week to equalize moisture.

FUN FACT

Conditioning helps prevent mold by removing leftover moisture pockets.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables



Q

How does curing help in making bacon at home?

DEHYDRATING AND SMOKING



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

It uses salt and sometimes sugar to inhibit bacteria and preserve meat.

FUN FACT

Curing is a vital step to keep bacon safe and tasty before cooking.

Source: PNW 784 Making bacon at home



Q

Which of the following best describes the process of hot smoking fish?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Smoking followed by cooking to both flavor and cook the fish.

FUN FACT

Hot smoking gives better flavor and prevents a baked fish taste.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home



Q

Why is airflow important in a dehydrator?

DEHYDRATING AND SMOKING



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

It helps remove moisture faster and ensures even drying.

FUN FACT

Rotating trays can also help dry foods evenly!

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables



Q

What is a sign that fruit leather is fully dried and ready to store?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

It is pliable and not sticky or moist to the touch.

FUN FACT

You can peel fruit leather from trays while still warm!

Source: SP 50-921 Drying herbs



Q

Why should fish pieces not overlap during brining?



ANSWER

Overlapping prevents uniform salt uptake and safe salting.

FUN FACT

Start with 15 minutes of brine time per half inch of fish thickness.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home



Q

What is a safe oven temperature for drying pumpkin seeds before roasting?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

115° to 120°F in a dehydrator

FUN FACT

Dry seeds before roasting for even cooking and better flavor.

Source: SP 50-921 Drying herbs



Q

What makes jerky a popular snack for hikers and hunters?



ANSWER

**It's lightweight, nutrient-dense,
and portable protein.**

FUN FACT

*Jerky has been enjoyed as a
high-energy food since ancient times!*

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely